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Survivors and Victims, a Meta-analytical Review of Fairness and Organizational Commitment after Downsizing

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There is a lack of consistent evidence that downsizing leads to improved financial performance. Lowered commitment after painful downsizing periods is identified as an important reason why downsizing does not show the intended long-term effects. This paper provides a meta-analytical overview of the impact of fairness on organizational commitment for survivors and victims after a downsizing operation. Among 37 samples (11,256 persons), a positive relationship was found between fairness and affective organizational commitment ($\rho = 0.40$) for both survivors and victims. Three moderators of the fairness–commitment relationship were identified: (1) for survivors, procedural justice matters more than distributive justice; (2) the impact of fairness is stronger in countries with an individualistic (versus collectivistic) culture; (3) fairness matters more when mass layoff is initiated for profit maximization (versus economic necessity).

Introduction

Increased work productivity, technological advances, outsourcing to cheaper labour countries and global competition have led to a continuing downsizing in American and European companies. In addition, the financial crisis has accelerated mass layoffs across all sectors in Europe and the USA. During the first quarter of 2010, according to the US Bureau of Labor Statistics, employers in the USA conducted 4884 mass layoff actions. Each action involved at least 50 individuals, totalling 466,610 people. Downsizing, which is the permanent and involuntary letting go of employees by management, has become a household word in many companies. Downsizing and mass layoffs are certainly not a new phenomenon triggered by the rise of the financial crisis, but this trend, which had started already in the 1980s and 1990s, was ongoing even in a time of labour market shortages. In the 21st century, organizational restructuring through downsizing is a popular solution in order to survive in a competitive market (Guthrie and Datta, 2008; Tyler and Wilkinson, 2007). Even companies that are well run and financially successful use layoffs as part of their regular business strategy to stay on top of their game. However, evidence for the effects on firm performance is inconclusive (Datta *et al.*, 2010), and even within firms that reported increased firm performance, data suggest that labour productivity of the remaining work force decreased (Baumol, Blinder and Wolff, 2003).

Especially in times of crisis, organizations depend on the commitment of their employees (Baumol, Blinder and Wolff, 2003). It is safe to say that a layoff has serious effects on all individuals involved, especially on the so-called downsizing victims and survivors. There is general agreement that downsizing results in reduced organizational commitment among survivors (for an overview see Datta *et al.*, 2010). Therefore, lowered commitment of employees after painful downsizing periods is identified as one of the reasons why downsizing often does not

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show the intended long-term effects (Brockner, 1988; Cameron, 1994; Cascio and Wynn, 2004).

Fairness is frequently positioned as a crucial factor influencing the commitment of employees towards their employers: justly treated employees are more committed (Cropanzano, Bowen and Gilliland, 2007). From a justice perspective, downsizing is an especially relevant case. There is ample evidence that the way in which a company manages its layoff impacts the layoff survivors' fairness perceptions, organizational commitment and intent to leave (for an overview see Skarlicki and Kulik, 2005). A downsizing operation breaches the implicit and explicit expectations between employees and employers, that the employee's contribution to the organization will be reciprocated with a stable and positive work environment, and thus that good performance will result in safe employment (Charness and Levine, 2000; Gerlach *et al*., 2008; Kozlowski *et al*., 1993). This violation of expectations is perceived as most painful under those circumstances where the process and the outcomes are experienced as unfair (Cropanzano and Prehar, 2001; Zatzick and Iverson, 2006).

Justice research has traditionally focused on a dyad, i.e. employee and organization. Studies on downsizing also consider this dyadic relationship, thus victim and organization, but more often focus on survivors. The latter perspective goes beyond the dyad, since survivors are so-called 'third parties'. Although survivors are not directly affected by justice (mis)treatment by their organization, the observation of the treatment of victims is likely to impact survivors' attitudes and behaviours. The third party perspective is important for organizations in the downsizing context. The reaction of victims to organizational treatment is observed by third parties within the organization, i.e. survivors, and outside the organization, i.e. customers or potential job candidates. Skarlicki, Ellard and Kelln (1998) found that fairness perceptions of layoffs influenced third parties' intentions to buy the company's products and to apply for jobs at the company at which the layoff occurred. As third parties within the organization, survivors learn about their organization by observing the treatment of victims. These observations can affect their job attitudes and behaviours.

Consequently, the link between fairness and organizational commitment within the downsizing context has often been studied. These empirical studies have shown a high degree of variability in the strength of the relationship between fairness and organizational commitment. The purpose of this paper is to provide a better insight into this variability by producing a state of the art meta-analytical review based on three decades of research in the field. Additionally, it aims to identify research gaps and relevant theoretical perspectives for future studies. We use a meta-analytical approach to provide a well-grounded overview of the current research and to examine potential moderators. An earlier meta-analysis on antecedents, correlates and consequences of organizational commitment confirmed the importance of fairness (Meyer *et al*., 2002). No attention, however, was given to the variance across studies in terms of the specific context and setting. As such, by providing an enhanced insight into processes that influence the link between fairness and organizational commitment, our paper contributes both to the downsizing literature and to the fairness and organizational commitment literature.

An important advantage of a meta-analytical approach is that hypotheses that go beyond insights provided by the individual papers or narrative reviews can be studied and tested. A meta-analysis also allows for the correction of sampling error and measurement reliability to provide us with an estimate of the average population correlations (Hunter and Schmidt, 2004). By providing a multi-study overview, this meta-analysis allows us to study three moderators that can be considered important for understanding the divergence within the relation between fairness and organizational commitment in the downsizing context:

(1) The personal situation of the people involved (victims versus survivors). Layoffs affect employees differently: dismissed employees are influenced by a layoff in another way than their colleagues who stay with the company (Brockner *et al*., 1994; Skarlicki, Ellard and Kelln, 1998).
(2) The cultural context of the decision (individualism versus collectivism). In a globalized world it increasingly matters for multinationals that there are substantial cross-cultural variations in the preference for fairness rules in the downsizing context (Gerlach *et al*., 2008; Leung, 2005; Segalla, Jacobs and Müller, 2001). Cultural norms can influence

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the general importance of fairness perceptions in the downsizing context.

(3) The reason for the layoff (economic necessity versus profit maximization). The arguments given for a layoff impact the influence of the fairness perception of the downsizing operation. In the eyes of the employees, these arguments can reveal the degree of accountability of a company for the layoff (Brockner, 2002; Gopinath and Becker, 2000). When a downsizing operation takes place due to reasons beyond the influence of the company, fairness perceptions are less relevant than in the case of a layoff that was implemented as a strategic instrument in order to maximize profit.

This paper is organized as follows. We first discuss the state of the art in fairness and commitment after downsizing. Then we present our five hypotheses in which we introduce the three moderators. After reporting our methodology and results we summarize our findings in the discussion and particularly pinpoint research gaps in the broader context of downsizing operations.

Fairness and downsizing

Three aspects of organizational fairness are generally distinguished (Greenberg and Lind, 2000). (1) Distributive fairness (Adams, 1965; Homans, 1961; Walster, Berscheid and Walster, 1973) reflects the outcomes resulting from the downsizing, e.g. in the sense that victims feel that the severance benefits provided are adequate. (2) Procedural fairness (Lind and Tyler, 1988; Thibaut and Walker, 1975) reflects the fairness of the procedures used to implement the downsizing. For procedural fairness, consistency regarding people and time is essential, as are aspects such as lack of bias, the possibility to correct wrong decisions (Clay-Warner, Hegtveldt and Roman, 2005) and the opportunity to provide information (voice) during the decision-making process (Lind and Tyler, 1988). (3) Interactional fairness (Bies, 2001; Bies and Moag, 1986) focuses on the interpersonal side of organizational practices in terms of the dignity and respect with which (bad) news is delivered to the individuals involved and the information provided in terms of the clarity and the adequateness of the explanation given by management.

Within this study, we will treat interactional justice as an element of procedural justice. Despite arguments from some authors that procedural and interactional justice can be considered as theoretically distinct constructs (for an overview see Bies, 2005), we follow Blader and Tyler (2003) who interpret interactional justice as a specific aspect that can hierarchically be placed within the broader framework of procedural justice. According to Blader and Tyler's (2003) four-component model of procedural justice, behaviour within the dismissal context such as the communications by the supervisor is most probably perceived by the employees as acts and incidences of communication that symbolise the position of the organization and thus exemplify procedural justice (Rhoades and Eisenberger, 2002). This is acknowledged by the fact that many studies on justice effects within the downsizing context measure interactional fairness as an aspect of procedural justice and not as a separate dimension (e.g. Brockner *et al.*, 1994; Mansour-Cole and Scott, 1998).

Fairness information provides a relevant source for sensemaking processes (Brockner, 2002; Weick, 1995) of employees. An important element of sensemaking is for organizational members to determine the reasons for the outcome of their social exchanges within the organization; for example, procedural fairness information is used to determine the exchange partner's level of responsibility for the outcome. In organizational settings, social exchange takes place in ongoing relationships. Under this condition, as suggested by fairness heuristic theory (Van den Bos *et al.*, 1999), people use procedural fairness information not only to assess the level of responsibility for the outcome, but also to determine the nature of their relationships with their exchange partners. In other words, employees use justice information to find out if their organizational authorities can be trusted. The more uncertain the situation is – and downsizing is characterized by high uncertainty – the higher the need is to engage in sensemaking processes and to use fairness information for these processes (Van den Bos and Lind, 2002; Weick, 1995).

Negative psychological consequences in the downsizing context are especially relevant to consider, since employees also use procedural fairness information to evaluate their personal responsibility for their outcomes. Downsizing changes the way in which people think about organizations and also about themselves as

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employees (Cropanzano and Prehar, 2001). After fair procedures employees are less likely to blame managers for unfavourable outcomes, which may – as a result – elicit negative self-evaluations, especially among victims of the downsizing process. Brockner (2002, p. 60) states: 'On the one hand, greater procedural fairness may lead employees to be more supportive of the [. . .] organization. On the other hand, greater procedural fairness may lower employees' evaluations of themselves.'

Fairness and affective organizational commitment

Commitment can broadly be defined as 'a force [that] binds an individual to a course of action that is of relevance to a particular target' (Meyer and Herscovitch, 2001, p. 301). In studies on organizational commitment, different forms of commitment were distinguished, namely affective, continuance and normative commitment (see for example Allen and Meyer, 1996; Meyer and Allen, 1991; Meyer *et al*., 2002). Although such different bases of commitment in the workplace have different causes and implications, Mathieu and Zajac (1990) concluded that affective involvement tends to be most relevant as a behavioural predictor in general. Several meta-analyses confirmed the essential role of affective organizational commitment by showing relationships with a broad range of attitudes and behaviours at work that are all crucial elements within the downsizing context, including job performance, turnover, absenteeism and organizational citizenship behaviours (e.g. Mathieu and Zajac, 1990; Meyer *et al*., 2002; Riketta and Van Dick, 2005). Furthermore, several studies have shown that affective commitment proved to be the strongest correlate of justice perceptions (for an overview see Meyer *et al*., 2002).

Affective organizational commitment can be seen as 'an emotional attachment to, identification with, and involvement in the organization' (Meyer *et al*., 2002, p. 21). In general, there is a high risk that downsizing contributes to decreased affective organizational commitment for both survivors and victims. In particular, the long-term commitment of survivors is hereby critical for the kind of employee involvement necessary for the organization to turn its performance around following a downsizing (Datta *et al*., 2010).

Justice aspects of a downsizing operation provide important information about the trustworthiness of the organization in the eyes of the employees (Skarlicki and Kulik, 2005). Employees develop global beliefs concerning the extent to which the organization values their contributions and cares about their well-being (Rhoades and Eisenberger, 2002). Fairness is a crucial source for these beliefs, and commitment is a direct response of employees who feel well supported by their organizations.

Spreitzer and Mishra (2002) reported that positive perceptions of procedural and distributive fairness during downsizing enhanced the long-term commitment of survivors, and reduced their turnover intentions. This relationship between perceptions of fairness and organizational commitment has also been established in several other studies (Cohen-Charash and Spector, 2001; Colquitt *et al*., 2001; Meyer *et al*., 2002).

Obviously, the notification of a layoff has the most impact on the victims. These employees often remain for a significant period of time in their jobs, which can lead to counterproductive work behaviour out of frustration. Despite being allowed to stay in the organization, survivors are also influenced by the downsizing operation. Survivors and victims can respond to downsizing in significantly different ways. For example, although a layoff victim might feel mistreated, survivors can view the layoff as fair (Skarlicki, Ellard and Kelln, 1998). Alternatively, the intense reactions of victims can trigger solidarity from survivors (Skarlicki and Kulik, 2005). Brockner and Greenberg (1990) found that layoff survivors who identified with the victims tended to view the layoff as unfair. From a sensemaking perspective, it should be considered that survivors care about the justice involved in the treatment their colleagues encounter since they learn about the organization and its leaders by observing how others are treated. The perception of unfairness and overtly lowered commitment of victims after a layoff can have major effects on survivors in terms of a desire to punish the organization by lowering one's organizational commitment for unfair dismissal procedures (Folger, Cropanzano and Goldman, 2005; Skarlicki and Kulik, 2005). As such, it can be concluded that both victims and survivors care about fairness within a downsizing operation, which leads to our first hypothesis.

H1: Fairness during a layoff is positively related to affective organizational commitment.

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The influence of the personal situation: survivors and victims

In terms of continued affective commitment, survivors are the most relevant group for the organization. Survivors stay with the organization and they will need to turn the organization around after a difficult period of downsizing. Therefore it is of crucial importance to understand the justice-related influence on the affective commitment of survivors. Studies that looked simultaneously at the impact of distributive and procedural justice found a predominant influence of procedural justice on peoples' reactions in organizations. To capture the specific and distinct influence of these two justice dimensions, McFarlin and Sweeney (1992) introduced the two-factor model: distributive justice predicts personal outcomes such as pay satisfaction best, while procedural justice predicts system-referenced outcomes such as organizational commitment best. Distributive justice is typically not perceived as a good predictor of the general trustworthiness of an organization; procedural justice serves as fairness heuristic and a predictor for the general trustworthiness of the organization especially under the circumstances of heightened uncertainty (Van den Bos and Lind, 2002). Given that survivors experience a positive outcome – they belong to those who can stay – procedural justice will be the most important source to determine their future affective commitment to the company. Therefore we assume that survivors rely more on procedural justice than on distributive justice to determine the future trustworthiness of the organization and their organizational commitment.

> *H2*: In a downsizing context, among survivors, procedural fairness will be more strongly related to affective organizational commitment than distributive fairness.

Opposite to survivors, for victims downsizing is a form of negative selection where they are confronted with the fact that the organization is terminating the relationship with them. According to the robust findings of the fair process effect, procedural justice matters even more when outcomes are unfavourable (for an overview see Brockner and Wiesenfeld, 2005). Dismissal is clearly an unfavourable outcome and therefore procedural justice should matter more for the affective organizational commitment of victims than of survivors. Next to this, dismissal is a threatening, negative event that triggers feelings of uncertainty, and even though victims are going to lose their employment with the company, their relationship with this organization still matters for them in order to understand their own role and accountability of the negative event. It has been shown that layoff victims suffer from long-term effects, such as the increased concern about job security also after re-employment (Kozlowski *et al*., 1993).

We assume that due to feelings of high uncertainty and in the face of the highly self-relevant negative outcome, victims have a higher need for sensemaking than survivors and therefore procedural justice matters more for victims than for survivors, which leads to the third hypothesis.

> *H3*: Within a downsizing context, procedural fairness is more strongly correlated with affective organizational commitment among victims than among survivors.

The influence of the context: culture and the reason for downsizing

Within this meta-analysis, we also explore the influence of national culture and of the economic reason for the downsizing operation. We are looking for overall effects across the entire population. In the following two hypotheses, we will therefore neither differentiate between forms of justice nor between survivors and victims.

There are substantial cross-cultural variations in the preference for justice rules (Leung, 2005). For example, in judging the fairness of pay levels, Americans emphasize (individualistic) performance, whereas Koreans emphasize (collectivistic) group-related criteria, such as seniority, education and family size (Hundley and Kim, 1997). Similar effects were also shown for procedural justice. In resolving a dispute, the Japanese regard relationship-related goals such as maintaining a positive relationship as more important than Americans do (Ohbuchi, Kukushima and Tedeschi, 1999). Segalla, Jacobs and Müller (2001) report that dismissal decisions across European banks are strongly driven by the nationality of the respondents. They found two distinct clusters of dismissal choices, and identified differing rationales for these choices. English human resource managers (more individualisti-

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cally oriented) use primarily performance-oriented criteria and preferably dismiss employees with the least productive worth for a company. German human resource managers (more collectivistic oriented) apply group-related criteria by also taking into account the impact of dismissal on the fired person and other colleagues.

There are still only a small number of studies exploring the cultural effect on the general importance of fairness. It was found that in countries high on power distance (Lam, Schaubroeck and Aryee, 2002) and also countries low on modernity (Farh, Earley and Lin, 1997), justice effects are weaker on organizational variables like organizational citizenship and job performance. These findings are in line with the results of a study across 43 countries that intrinsic job motivation (such as respectful treatment, recognition and personal achievement) matters less for job satisfaction in countries with low social security, high power distance and high collectivism (Huang and van de Vliert, 2003).

Of Hofstede's (2001) original four cultural value dimensions, we consider individualism–collectivism as the crucial one in the downsizing context. Individualism–collectivism is defined as the degree to which people in a country prefer to act as individuals rather than as members of a group (Hofstede, 2001). By excluding people from a group, dismissal touches at the heart of this dimension.

Members of individualistic countries are more likely to see themselves in an exchange relationship with their organizations and to stress their individual rights, while members of collectivistic cultures tend to emphasize the views, needs and goals of their organization rather than their own interests. Employees in collectivistic countries tend to value self-actualization and individual recognition by the organization less than employees from individualistic countries (Huang and van de Vliert, 2003). Thus, members of individualistic cultures might also be more likely to use justice considerations to evaluate their exchange relationship with the organization and to determine their organizational commitment to their organization than members of collectivistic countries.

H4: Fairness has a stronger effect on affective organizational commitment in individualistic countries than in collectivistic countries.

With respect to the reasons for starting a downsizing operation, we differentiate between profit maximization and economic necessity. Here we focus on accountability, which is a fundamental aspect of organizational justice, namely the question regarding to what extent another party is to be considered as blameworthy: 'If no one is to blame, there is no social injustice' (Folger and Cropanzano, 2001, p. 1). The perceived accountability for the downsizing operation will therefore influence the impact that fairness perceptions of the procedures and decision have on organizational commitment (Brockner, 2002; Skarlicki and Kulik, 2005). Employees evaluate whether other options were available and explored by management before action was taken (Greenhalgh, Lawrence and Sutton, 1988). As such, the legitimacy of the layoff decision is also determined by the existence of layoffs in other companies in the same industry (Brockner, 1988). Fairness information on a layoff which is driven by purely for profit intentions, and thus under the condition of high accountability, will be experienced as more relevant and of stronger influence than within a downsizing operation which takes place due to general economic conditions that are beyond the control of the management, and thus under the condition of low accountability. When there is an economic necessity, the layoff decision cannot be fully attributed to the organization. This (partial) lack of control of the organization will make fairness information less relevant for organizational commitment.

H5: Within downsizing operations based on profit maximization, fairness will matter more for affective organizational commitment than in downsizing operations due to economic necessity.

Our overall research model is depicted in Figure 1.

Method

Literature search and inclusion criteria

First, a computerized search into the Psycinfo database (1970–2009) was used to identify appropriate studies for the present meta-analysis. The following search terms were used: 'downsizing', 'restructuring', 'layoff' and 'layoffs'. Second, studies cited in narrative reviews on downsizing were checked. Third, a web-based search with the search engine Google Scholar was performed to determine the existence of unpublished studies. Fourth, the 15 top-tier peer-reviewed journals within the

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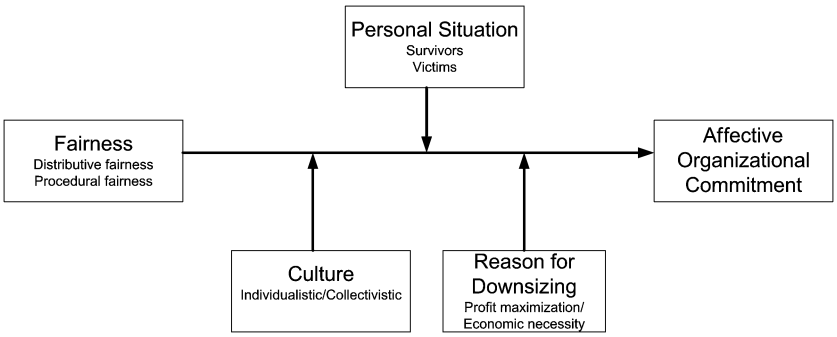


Figure 1. Conceptual model of fairness and affective organizational commitment after downsizing

organizational behaviour and management field were manually searched from 1980 onwards for papers missed (e.g. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, *Academy of Management Journal*, *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, *Human Resource Management*, *Administrative Science Quarterly*). Fifth, the authors from the studies uncovered in the previous steps were sent a personal email to ask for any unpublished data or studies in press that could be included in our meta-analysis.

The search resulted in 273 potential studies on downsizing. All abstracts were checked for relevance to be included in this meta-analysis. A study was considered for inclusion if it covered both fairness and organizational commitment. The resulting papers with relevant concepts in the abstracts were all read. To be included in the meta-analysis, the data necessary for calculating the effect size had to be provided. The end result was a database including 37 studies with 11,256 respondents. Twenty-nine studies appeared in peer-reviewed international journals and eight were unpublished dissertation studies, which meant that we could include a sufficient proportion of unpublished studies in our sample to avoid publication bias problems. Publication bias, also called the file-drawer effect, is a potential bias for meta-analysis given that statistically significant results may enhance the chance of a study being published in peer-reviewed journals. The inclusion of non-published studies therefore enhances the ability to generalize the outcomes of a meta-analysis.

All studies measuring some form of affective organizational commitment were included. In total, ten different commitment scales were used. Most papers used the affective commitment scale of Meyer and Allen (1991), followed by the organizational commitment questionnaire of Mowday, Steers and Porter (1979), Schwyhart and Smith (1972) and O'Reilly and Chatman (1986), in 12, six, five and four studies, respectively. Not all studies used the original scales; sometimes the scale was shortened or was slightly adjusted. The measurement based on the last three commitment scales all used items that captured the core of affective commitment (see Fields (2002) for an overview).

Fairness was measured with self-developed items in almost all studies. Most of the time, one or more items were formulated either based on general fairness measures or directly inspired by organizational justice literature (e.g. Leventhal, 1980). The measure developed by Brockner, Tyler and Cooper-Schneider (1992) was the only one used to measure fairness in five other studies. Distributive fairness was measured in 16 studies. Twenty-seven studies included measures of procedural fairness.

Meta-analysis procedures

This study used the Hunter–Schmidt psychometric meta-analysis method (Hunter and Schmidt, 2004) to integrate the reported correlations between fairness and organizational commitment. The correlations were corrected for the random effect of sampling error and the systematic attenuation produced by error of measurement in both the fairness and commitment scales using the internal consistency reliability. The majority of the studies included provided the reliabilities for these scales. For the few instances where the internal consistency was not provided (i.e. three of the 37 studies), the average value across the other studies was used. The average internal consistency value for fairness was 0.82 and for commitment 0.85.

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To describe the variability in the meta-analytical estimates, the 80% credibility intervals and the 90% confidence intervals around the estimated population correlations are reported. Credibility intervals indicate the variability of the individual correlations across studies. An interval of 80% indicates the boundaries of 80% of the values in the correlation distribution. Confidence intervals express the likely amount of error in our estimate of the population correlation due to sampling error. Credibility intervals are calculated with the standard deviation of the population correlation; confidence intervals are calculated with the standard error of the population correlation.

Results

Table 1 presents the results for the overall relationship between fairness and affective organizational commitment, as well as the differentiated results for survivors compared with victims and procedural versus distributive fairness. To calculate the overall population estimate, one mean correlation was entered for each study. Thus, if both victims and survivors were surveyed in a study, or both types of fairness were included, one overall value for the correlation between fairness and commitment was calculated. In the moderator analysis, effect sizes were calculated for each specific moderator. Not all studies provided the necessary data to separate survivors from victims or procedural from distributive fairness. This explains why the number of studies and the number of respondents in the moderator analysis do not add up exactly to the overall values in the first row.

The overall population value of the relationship between fairness and affective organizational commitment among employees undergoing a downsizing operation is strong ($\rho = 0.40$), which is a confirmation of our first hypothesis. Sampling error accounts for only 13% of the variance which suggests that moderating effects influence the differences in effect sizes between the studies. The relationship of overall fairness and organizational commitment was the same for victims and for survivors.

For procedural fairness, the average population correlation was significantly larger than for distributive fairness ($\rho = 0.41$ versus $\rho = 0.31$; z score = 6.93, $p < 0.001$). The procedure suggested by Preacher (2002) was used to calculate the significance between correlations. Next, we checked whether our argument to collapse interactional and procedural fairness was confirmed by the data. Thirteen studies (including 4533 participants) either clearly studied interactional fairness or provided separate values for procedural fairness and interactional fairness. The average corrected correlation was only slightly, and not significantly, lower than that for procedural fairness as a whole ($r = 0.27$, $\rho = 0.38$, $SD\rho = 0.09$; z score = 1.62, $p = 0.11$), thus confirming our argument. The remainder of the analyses were performed for one score of procedural fairness.

Table 1. Meta-analysis results of the relationship between fairness and affective organizational commitment

	k	N	r	ρ	SD_ρ	80% CV lower	80% CV upper	95% CI lower	95% CI upper
Overall	37	11256	0.31	0.40	0.13	0.21	0.59	0.29	0.51
Individualistic	32	8008	0.36	0.42	0.15	0.23	0.62	0.30	0.54
Profit maximization	5	928	0.39	0.46	0.11	0.33	0.60	0.32	0.61
Economic necessity	13	3559	0.29	0.34	0.16	0.14	0.55	0.22	0.46
Collectivistic	5	3248	0.21	0.32	0.12	0.16	0.47	0.22	0.41
Survivors	28	8041	0.35	0.41	0.15	0.22	0.60	0.30	0.52
Victims	8	1415	0.34	0.41	0.15	0.22	0.61	0.27	0.56
Procedural fairness	27	8449	0.31	0.41	0.10	0.28	0.54	0.29	0.52
Survivors	19	5342	0.38	0.44	0.09	0.32	0.55	0.33	0.55
Victims	7	1328	0.33	0.40	0.15	0.21	0.59	0.25	0.55
Distributive fairness	16	6430	0.23	0.31	0.16	0.10	0.51	0.20	0.41
Survivors	14	4543	0.26	0.31	0.16	0.10	0.52	0.21	0.42

Note: One study reported joint data for the survivors and victims and was not included in the separate analysis for survivors and victims. Only one study focused on distributive fairness for victims. k, number of studies; N, respondents in studies; r, uncorrected correlation; ρ, corrected correlation; SD, standard deviation; CV, credibility interval; CI, confidence interval.

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To test our second hypothesis, we calculated the differential influence of both forms of fairness for the survivors only. Among this group, there was a larger correlation with organizational commitment for procedural fairness than for distributive fairness ($\rho = 0.44$ versus $\rho = 0.31$). This difference was significant and in the expected direction (z score = 7.51, $p < 0.001$), thus confirming the hypothesis.

The third hypothesis – on the greater sensitivity of victims (versus survivors) to procedural fairness – was rejected. The difference between both groups for the average corrected correlation ($\rho = 0.44$ versus $\rho = 0.40$) was not significant (z score = 1.58, $p = 0.11$). We have to conclude that we can find no indication for differences between survivors and victims regarding sensitivity towards procedural fairness in its relation to organizational commitment.

Next, we checked whether the degree of individualism–collectivism within a country played a role for the impact of fairness on organizational commitment, in line with Hypothesis 4. The estimation of the level of individualism was based on Hofstede (2001), a high score indicating more individualism and a low score indicating more collectivism. In this meta-analysis, 32 studies included samples from individualistic countries (27 studies from the USA (individualism score 91), two from Canada (individualism score 80) and three from Australia (individualism score 90). Five studies came from countries with a collectivistic culture: two studies from South Korea (individualism score 18), one study from Hong Kong (individualism score 25) and two studies from Russia (individualism score 39). We compared the individualistic sample with the collectivistic sample. The average corrected correlation for the individualistic samples was significantly larger than for the collectivistic samples ($\rho = 0.42$ versus $\rho = 0.32$; z score = 5.58, $p < 0.001$), thus confirming our hypothesis. We could not differentiate between survivors and victims since the individualistic sample included exclusively studies focused on survivors.

As a last step, and to further explore the role of the arguments given for the downsizing operation, two PhD students who were unaware of the goal of the study were trained to independently code all studies according to the reasons given for the dismissals. The studies were coded as to whether the reason for downsizing was purely for profit or due to reasons caused by developments outside the organization. In the case of different coding, agreement was achieved between the two coders in a second step. In five studies, the reason for downsizing was purely for profit. All these samples were from individualistic countries. In 17 studies, economic conditions or government budget cuts forced the organization to downsize. Seven samples could not be coded because a composite sample was used with subjects drawn from different companies. In the remaining six samples, the reason for the layoff was unclear from the description in the Method section of the papers. Even though we contacted the authors we were not able to get clarification in these six cases. The average corrected correlation for the subsample of the five downsizing-for-profit studies was 0.46 ($N = 928$). The average corrected correlation in the 17 samples where the downsizing took place due to general economic reasons or government cuts was significantly lower, namely $\rho = 0.32$ ($N = 6524$). To control for the cultural effect we excluded all samples from collectivistic countries from the downsizing group for reasons of economic necessity. After these four samples were removed, the average correlation for the remaining samples (thus, all from individualistic countries; this is the subgroup that is reported in Table 1) was $\rho = 0.34$ ($N = 3559$), and again significantly lower (z score = 3.88, $p < 0.001$) than in the downsizing-for-profit studies. So, Hypothesis 5 was also confirmed.

Discussion

This study addressed the relationship between fairness and affective organizational commitment for survivors and victims of a downsizing operation. This is an important issue in times when even companies on *Fortune*'s 'Best company to work for' list (such as Motorola, Xerox and IBM) are laying people off. Overall, a moderately strong relationship was found with an estimated population correlation of 0.40. Among survivors, procedural fairness was more important than distributive fairness. In countries with an individualistic culture, fairness was of more importance in relation to organizational commitment than in countries with a collectivistic culture. Moreover, if the downsizing operation was carried out for profit reasons, this sensitivity

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was stronger than when the primary reason was economic necessity.

The first contribution made by this paper is that the overall relationship between fairness and affective organizational commitment within the context of downsizing dovetails with the results reported in meta-analysis on the influence of fairness in the day-to-day functioning of organizations (Cohen-Charash and Spector, 2001; Meyer *et al*., 2002). Our confirmation is an important finding since the darker sides of organizational realities are often forgotten, and especially in the rough times of organizational downsizing soft factors like fairness and commitment tend to be systematically neglected. Our results indicate that explicit attention to fairness within the downsizing process is a vital driver of continued commitment in the crucial time following a downsizing operation. The strong overall corrected correlation stresses the importance of fairness for continued affective organizational commitment also after painful periods in organizational life.

The second contribution of our meta-analysis is the particular importance of procedural justice (versus distributive justice) for survivors (Folger and Konovsky, 1989; McFarlin and Sweeney, 1992; Tyler *et al*., 1997). Like all periods of organizational change, times of organizational downsizing are times of high uncertainty that trigger sensemaking processes. Employees who felt that they were given full and fair explanation of why and how people were dismissed are more likely to accept the layoff process, and to remain more positive about the organization.

There is much evidence that managerial communication has a general positive effect on affective organizational commitment after a layoff. This is not only an indirect effect through enhanced perceptions of procedural justice but also a direct effect; thus both roles of procedural justice and managerial communication play an important role for commitment after downsizing (Gopinath and Becker, 2000). This suggests that the tendency to centralize responsibility for communicating relevant organizational moves by means of the human resource department should be reconsidered. Survivors perceive procedures surrounding layoffs as fairer when their direct supervisors personally inform them (Mansour-Cole and Scott, 1998).

The third contribution of our meta-analysis is that the importance of procedural fairness was relevant to victims. Although our hypothesis that this relationship would be stronger for victims than for survivors had to be rejected, the average corrected correlation was still moderately strong and similar to the population correlation. As such, it can be assumed that respect for victims in terms of procedural fairness may give victims a feeling of being valued (Konovsky and Folger, 1991) and also lowers their intention to take their past employer to court (Wanberg, Bunce and Gavin, 1999). This is an interesting conclusion, since most organizations fail in terms of transparency when it comes to termination decisions. Brockner (1994) suggested that one reason for this might be the fear of organizations that more transparency would provide employees with crucial information they could use in lawsuits against the organization. The opposite might be true, namely that organizations could prevent expensive lawsuits by providing their employees with the information instead of anxiously hiding it. The importance for organizations of using fair procedures with respect to victims also becomes clear in light of the fact that people who have been laid off may be considered for re-employment later when the economy picks up again.

It should be acknowledged, however, that there is a downside to procedural fairness. High procedural justice may cause people to see themselves as more responsible. There is an inverse relationship between procedural justice and self-esteem when outcomes are unfavourable (Schroth and Shah, 2000). This finding makes the practice of high procedural fairness controversial: on the one hand, it is related to more organizational commitment, and on the other hand, it may be damaging to self-esteem when outcomes are unfavourable. This controversy is certainly an area warranting more research.

The fourth contribution is that evidence was presented for the moderating effects of culture on the relationship between fairness and commitment. Studies from individualistic cultures showed a significantly larger average correlation between fairness and affective organizational commitment ($\rho = 0.42$ versus $\rho = 0.32$) than studies from collectivistic countries. It is an interesting finding in itself that the studies from individualistic cultures exclusively focus on survivors and seem to neglect the victim perspective. To speculate about cultural influences on research interests would be going too far, since the

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empirical basis is still relatively thin. A systematic exploration of the effects of the cultural context on the effects of dismissal is certainly warranted.

Fifth, indications were found in our meta-analysis that a layoff which is driven purely for profit will be experienced differently from a downsizing which takes place due to economic necessities that are beyond the control of the management. Within a purely for profit downsizing operation the justice perspective matters more. Under this condition, the fairness–organizational commitment relationship is significantly stronger than in situations where the downsizing could be explained by general economic constraints. An interesting avenue for future research is the impact of the reasons for dismissal and the perceived accountability of the organization on the psychological consequences among employees.

Of course, this study also has some limitations. Most importantly, only 37 studies were found that fulfilled all inclusion criteria. As a result, the moderator analysis is only partly hierarchical (Hunter and Schmidt, 2004). There were simply not enough studies for a full hierarchical breakdown of all moderator variables. This means that one must be cautious about generalizing in terms of the conclusions. For example, the influence of downsizing based on profit maximization versus economic necessity could only be studied within individualistic countries. As such, we do not know how this will play out in collectivistic countries. Nevertheless, the direction of the effects in the moderator analysis is intriguing and very helpful in suggesting lines of future research. Another limitation was that only in one study was the distributive fairness for victims reported. We would like to encourage future research to consider more strongly the victims of dismissal decisions, which is clearly an under-researched area. A third limitation is the influence of sample bias ('file-drawer problem'). It may be that studies that revealed no significant effect have never been published, nor were they part of a doctoral dissertation. The number of additional studies with a zero effect that are needed to significantly bring down the reported effect sizes can be calculated (Hunter and Schmidt, 2004). For example, it would take 36 additional studies with a zero effect to bring the overall effect size down from 0.40 to 0.20. It would take 108 studies with a zero effect to bring the overall effect size down to 0.10. We can therefore conclude that sample bias is not likely to undermine our conclusions.

In conclusion, our findings clearly have practical implications. Although it may be tempting for management to get quickly over the inconvenient phase of downsizing, in the long run a careful and fair procedure will pay off. It is likely that having the commitment of the survivors to go for it will make all the difference between a successful and a not so successful downsizing operation.

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